who aimed at middle-class voters in Gush Dan, the coastal plain around Tel Aviv. Kulanu aims a similar message at the “periphery”. Fewer than 7 per cent of Israeli voters live in Tel Aviv, but Meretz receives more than 20 per cent of its votes in the city.

As Lapid tries to become a national leader, though, he finds himself mired in contradictions. In an effort to improve relations with the diaspora, for example, he promises to implement the mixed-gender prayer area at the Western Wall “in his first week” as prime minister. But that would be a hard sell with the ultra-Orthodox, his prospective coalition partners. Bennett, as mentioned earlier, faces the same obstacle with the religious nature of his party.

The political spectrum in Israel is a confusing multi-dimensional construct, with different spectra for war and peace, religion and state, the economy, and other issues. The rising star of Israeli politics is a man who tries to stake out the least offensive position on each one—and, in doing so, implicitly promises not to resolve them. “We really need to talk about things like better law enforcement, more traffic police,” Zivan said at one point, trying to steer the conversation away from questions of peace and diplomacy. “I realize these aren’t the most exciting issues. But if we’re elected, we’ll enact as many of them as possible.”